Chinese firms will accept host-nation processing demands and build domestic beneficiation plants across Southern Africa over the next 12 months, deepening technological lock-in rather than losing control of critical mineral supply chains.

75%

PROBABILITY

▲ from 70%

TARGET:

CONFIDENCE:

WHAT'S NEW

- Zimbabwe's Finance Minister opened talks with China Railway on resource-backed infrastructure financing at WEF Dalian, extending the infrastructure-for-resources model to transport infrastructure collateralized by mineral wealth, modeled on DRC's $7bn Sicomines deal (Source 23)
- BRICS activated as an institutional buffer against G7 de-risking — Wang Yi called for deeper strategic minerals cooperation at the June 2026 BRICS National Security Advisors meeting, with China's embedded position across BRICS supply nodes making clean Western decoupling impossible (Source 25)
- EU launched its first-ever investment roadshow in South Africa, announcing a €12B package under the 2025 EU-SA Clean Trade and Investment Partnership with local beneficiation as a condition (Source 11)
- Kamoa-Kakula copper smelter — Africa's largest — became operational in DRC, with Zijin Mining holding a 39.6% stake, marking a major escalation in Chinese-backed domestic mineral processing (Source 16)
- Tsingshan Holding Group entered Zimbabwe's lithium sector via a Sandawana Mine JV with state-owned Mutapa Energy Minerals and Zhejiang Huayou Cobalt, bringing a second major Chinese industrial conglomerate into the country (Source 24)
- Tanzania formalized a structural resource governance shift — mandating local processing, state participation, and regulatory oversight — as part of a continental renegotiation wave alongside DRC, Zimbabwe, and Namibia (Source 21)
- China's maritime integration extended beyond port construction to include operations software, automation, AI, cybersecurity systems, and maritime training programmes across African ports (Source 18)
- Zimbabwe's Q1 2026 mineral revenue rose 79% (to $983.85M) following the raw lithium export ban, providing hard data that validates the beneficiation-forcing model (Source 24)

ANALYSIS